O-4714 • Painting • The Ghosts of Vimy Ridge

Painting

Specifications

Artists	William Longstaff (Artist) • Bourlet (maker)
Date	1929 circa
Signature	William Longstaff
Inscriptions	*JAMES BOURLET & SONS // LTD //PICTURES RELINED, CLEANED & VARNISHED // Artist....Capt. W. Longstaff // Ref. No....Da // 7th January, 1931 //17 & 18 Nassau Street W1*
Materials	paint, oil
Support	wood, unidentified • canvas
Dimensions (cm)	**303.2** (Width) • **171.8** (Height) • **16.0** (Depth)
Functions	Art

The Ghosts of Vimy Ridge

On Easter Sunday, 1917, Canadian soldiers launched a bloody, victorious attack on the German-held Vimy Ridge. This battle is considered a defining moment for Canada coming into its own as a young country.

In William Longstaff's oil painting, The Ghosts of Vimy Ridge, the spectres of almost 3,600 fallen Canadian soldiers trod back to camp, through shell-pocked ground and darkness, guided by light from below that illuminates Walter Allward's massive Canadian monument.

Longstaff, an Australian, sold the painting to Captain John Arthur Dewer, of the Dewer distillery family, who presented it to Canadian Prime Minister R.B. Bennett in 1931.

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